



DAMMING EFFECTS

The impact of the pressure on the Ganga upstream is being felt downstream in West Bengal

2,800 HECTARE
Fertile land lost to erosion so far

700 THOUSAND
recorded homeless; actual number could well be close to a million

₹1,000 CRORE
Government estimate of loss of property due to erosion

32 Already existing barrages on Ganga in 7 states

16 New barrages planned

JURISDICTION OF FARAKKA BARRAGE AUTHORITY (FBA)

FROM 2005 TO 2017	CURRENT JURISDICTION
40 KM Upstream	12.5 KM Upstream
80 KM Downstream	6.9 KM Downstream

In a November 2014 report 'Lessons from Farakka', a group of river experts working with SANDRP (South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers and People) sounded an alert on the possible impact of the proposed barrages: "We have seen how a single dam (Farakka Barrage) on the Ganga in Bengal has been playing havoc with the lives of millions of people every year for the past two decades," says the report. "The impact of 16 more such dams on this river, having one of the highest silt loads, densest of populations and one of the largest deltas at its mouth, forebodes an unimaginable doom on the river and its ecosystem."

Prof. Sugata Hazra, former director of oceanographic studies at Jadavpur University, cannot agree more. The new barrages, he thinks, will multiply the potential of human and ecological disasters.

However, not everyone blames siltation and barrages for the river changing course. R. Azhagesan, a former general manager of the Farakka Barrage Authority (FBA), says, "Sedimentation is one of the reasons, but not the principal one. We also have to factor in the river's morphological changes, its velocity, the water current, bank stability and vegetation on the banks."

Other experts believe that every river has a tendency to oscillate, the answer lies in rehabilitation. "Scientific land use and relocating habitats from the river bank can save lives," says river expert Kalyan Rudra, "but that is not possible in the densely populated districts of Malda and Murshidabad."

EMPTY ASSURANCES

Until recently, the threat of erosion was the highest towards the end of the monsoon. This is when the water recedes—usually in the dry months of September to December—and the dried-up soil becomes loose and often caves in. However, with the region getting moderate to heavy rain through most of the year since 2021, the threat of erosion now persists for most part of the year. Between September 2021 and February 2022, Notun Shibpur, Chachandapur, Kamalpur and Nimtita in Murshidabad, and Sarkartola, Durgaramtola, Lalutola and Bhimagram in Malda, saw massive erosion.

In a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on February 21, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee pointed out that the river has claimed 2,800 hectares of land and displaced nearly 700,000 people in the past four decades. Yet, there is no rehabilitation package for those affected by river erosion. The Centre has clear-cut provisions and guidelines for compensating only the victims of natural disasters such as floods, cyclones, drought and earthquakes. There are no rehabilitation policies at the state level either. "With Bengal being the worst affected by rising sea levels and river bank erosion, there should be a state-specific rehabilitation plan," says Prof. Hazra.

What people get instead are empty assurances. Two elections—the 2021 assembly poll and the civic body polls this year—have come and gone, but the 2,000 families of Murshidabad, displaced in the recent erosion, have yet to receive the *pattas* (land deeds) they were promised. Mudassar Hossain, who contested on a CPI(M) ticket from Samserganj, alleges that those close to the ruling Trinamool Congress cornered all the government assistance even if their houses were intact.